

Simone de Beauvoir (Ethics):

Primary Focus: De Beauvoir's existentialist ethics revolves around the notion of authenticity and the moral responsibility to live authentically, especially in the face of ambiguity and societal pressures.

Interaction with Other Fields:

- **Metaphysics (Sartre):** De Beauvoir takes for granted Sartre's metaphysical proposition of radical freedom, using it as a basis to argue that in this freedom, individuals have an ethical responsibility to live authentically and resist "bad faith."
- **Epistemology (Camus):** While de Beauvoir focuses on the ethics of living authentically, she assumes the epistemological backdrop of Camus' Absurd – that the universe is inherently devoid of meaning. It's against this backdrop that the ethical imperative to create one's own meaning becomes even more poignant.

Jean-Paul Sartre (Metaphysics):

Primary Focus: Sartre's existentialist metaphysics centres on the idea of radical freedom and existence preceding essence.

Interaction with Other Fields:

- **Ethics (de Beauvoir & Frankl):** Sartre's notion of freedom sets the stage for de Beauvoir's ethical arguments about authenticity and Frankl's emphasis on the responsibility to find meaning. For both, the metaphysical freedom Sartre discusses becomes an ethical landscape in which individuals must navigate and find purpose.
- **Epistemology (Camus):** Sartre's metaphysics, which emphasises individual freedom and existence, assumes the epistemological framework of Camus' Absurd, suggesting that in a world without inherent meaning, individuals are free to create their own.

Albert Camus (Epistemology):

Primary Focus: Camus' epistemological existentialism revolves around the Absurd, the tension between humans' desire for meaning and the universe's inherent meaninglessness.

Interaction with Other Fields:

- **Ethics (de Beauvoir & Frankl):** Camus' exploration of the Absurd takes as given the ethical imperatives discussed by de Beauvoir and Frankl. In a world characterised by the Absurd, the ethical pursuits of authenticity and search for meaning become even more significant.
- **Metaphysics (Sartre):** Camus' epistemological stance assumes Sartre's metaphysical proposition that existence precedes essence and that individuals are free to shape their destinies in an Absurd universe.

Viktor Frankl (Ethics):

- **Primary Focus:** Frankl's existentialist ethics is anchored in the belief that despite suffering and life's challenges, individuals have a moral responsibility to search for meaning. This search for meaning, for Frankl, is not just a personal quest but an ethical imperative.
- **Interaction with Other Fields:**
 - **Metaphysics (Sartre):** Frankl's emphasis on the ethical responsibility to find meaning, especially in the face of suffering, builds upon Sartre's metaphysical proposition of radical freedom. While Sartre posits that we are "condemned to be free," Frankl suggests that within this freedom lies the ethical duty to find and create meaning.
 - **Epistemology (Camus):** While Frankl emphasises the ethical pursuit of meaning, he operates within the epistemological framework of Camus' Absurd. For Frankl, even in an Absurd universe, where objective meaning might be elusive, individuals can and should find personal meaning. This personal quest for meaning becomes an epistemological journey of understanding oneself and one's place in the universe.
 - **Ethics (de Beauvoir):** Both Frankl and de Beauvoir focus on the individual's responsibility in the face of freedom. While de Beauvoir emphasises the ethical importance of authenticity and confronting life's ambiguities, Frankl underscores the moral duty to find meaning, especially in adversity. Frankl's perspective can be seen as a complement to de Beauvoir's: where de Beauvoir speaks of the ethical challenge of living authentically in a world laden with ambiguity, Frankl provides a path, suggesting that even in the most challenging situations, one can and should seek purpose and meaning. Both philosophers offer an ethical framework for navigating the challenges of existence, with Frankl providing a more concrete method through logotherapy.

FUNDAMENTALS

Albert Camus is often associated with existentialism, but he personally preferred to be identified with the philosophy of the absurd. His work delves into the inherent tension between humans' search for meaning and the apparent meaninglessness of the universe. Here are the primary themes associated with Camus' philosophy:

1. **The Absurd:** Central to Camus' thought is the concept of the absurd. The absurd arises from the confrontation between our desire for understanding and order and the apparent indifference and chaos of the universe. In other words, it's the clash between our search for meaning and the universe's seeming lack of it.
2. **Revolt:** Instead of succumbing to despair in the face of the absurd, Camus believed in revolting against it. This revolt doesn't mean an external rebellion but an internal, personal confrontation with the absurdity of existence. By recognising the absurd and choosing to continue living in spite of it, individuals assert their existence and dignity.
3. **Freedom:** For Camus, acknowledging the absurdity of life leads to a kind of freedom. Without predetermined meaning or destiny, individuals are free to create their own values and make their own choices.
4. **Passion:** In a universe devoid of true meaning or order, Camus argued for living with intensity and passion. Instead of retreating into despair or nihilism, he believed in embracing life's experiences fully.
5. **Acceptance:** While Camus emphasises revolt against the absurd, he also speaks of accepting the absurdity of life. This acceptance doesn't mean passive resignation but a conscious acknowledgment of life's inherent contradictions.
6. **Ethics of Ambiguity:** Similar to some other existentialists, Camus believed that in a universe without inherent moral order, individuals must navigate an ethical landscape filled with ambiguity. Without clear moral guidelines, individuals must make choices based on personal integrity and responsibility.
7. **Death:** The inevitability of death is a recurring theme in Camus' work. He viewed death as the ultimate absurdity, emphasising the tension it creates: individuals search for meaning in a life that is ultimately finite and transient.
8. **Nature and Beauty:** In his works, especially in novels like "The Stranger," Camus often alludes to the beauty of nature and the physical world. For Camus, nature's indifference contrasts with human emotion and passion, further highlighting the absurdity of existence.

It's worth noting that while Camus dealt with themes common to existentialism, such as freedom, alienation, and individualism, he had a unique perspective on these topics. His emphasis on the absurd and his ideas on how to confront it distinguish him from other existentialist thinkers.

Biography of Albert Camus:

1. **Early Life:** Albert Camus was born in Mondovi, Algeria, in 1913, when Algeria was a French colony. His father died during World War I, and Camus was raised in relative poverty by his mother in the Belcourt section of Algiers.
2. **Education:** Despite the challenges of his upbringing, Camus was a bright student. He attended the University of Algiers, where he studied philosophy and was influenced by thinkers like Friedrich Nietzsche and Søren Kierkegaard.
3. **Tuberculosis:** In his youth, Camus contracted tuberculosis, a disease that affected him intermittently throughout his life. His personal confrontation with illness and mortality had a profound impact on his philosophical perspectives, especially on themes related to the absurdity of life and death.
4. **World War II:** During World War II, Camus joined the French Resistance against the Nazi occupation and became an editor for the underground newspaper "Combat." His experiences during the war deepened his reflections on freedom, revolt, and the human capacity for both cruelty and nobility.
5. **Literary Career:** Camus became a prominent novelist, essayist, and playwright. His notable works include "The Stranger," "The Plague," "The Myth of Sisyphus," and "The Fall." Through his writings, he explored the themes of absurdity, alienation, and revolt.
6. **Death:** Camus died tragically in a car accident in 1960 at the age of 46.

Camus and Existentialism:

1. **Relationship with Sartre:** Initially, Camus had a close intellectual and personal relationship with Jean-Paul Sartre, another towering figure of existentialism. However, they later had a public falling out, primarily due to ideological differences, especially concerning the role of political violence and their views on the Soviet Union.
2. **Absurdist vs. Existentialist:** While Camus is often categorised with the existentialists, he saw himself more as an absurdist. The core of his philosophy revolved around the tension between the human quest for meaning and the inherent meaninglessness of the universe.
3. **Influence of Nietzsche and Kierkegaard:** Like many existentialists, Camus was influenced by Friedrich Nietzsche's critique of traditional values and Søren Kierkegaard's focus on individual existence and choice.

Camus Among Contemporaries:

1. **Philosophical Landscape:** Camus' contemporaries included existentialist thinkers like Jean-Paul Sartre, Simone de Beauvoir, and Maurice Merleau-Ponty. While Camus shared certain themes with these thinkers, his emphasis on the absurd set him apart.
2. **Literary Context:** As a writer, Camus was also part of the post-war literary world, which grappled with the traumas of World War II and the Holocaust. Writers like Samuel Beckett and Franz Kafka influenced and echoed Camus' themes of absurdity and alienation.

In summary, Albert Camus' life experiences, from his upbringing in colonial Algeria to his role in the French Resistance, deeply influenced his philosophical perspectives. While he shared the existentialist stage with giants like Sartre and de Beauvoir, his unique emphasis on the absurd and

his skeptical approach to overarching ideologies distinguished him as a singular voice in 20th-century philosophy and literature.

Albert Camus' Philosophy:

1. The Absurd:

- **Concept:** At the heart of Camus' philosophy is the notion of the absurd. It emerges from the clash between our human desire for meaning and the seemingly indifferent, chaotic universe. For Camus, the realisation of this incongruity is fundamental to human existence.
- **Implication:** Accepting the absurd means recognising life's inherent lack of ultimate purpose or meaning. However, this acceptance should not lead to despair or nihilism.
- **Ought:** Instead of succumbing to the weight of the absurd, one ought to confront it head-on, embracing life with passion and intensity.

2. Revolt:

- **Concept:** Faced with the absurdity of existence, Camus advocates for revolt. This is not a physical rebellion but an internal, existential one—a consistent affirmation of life in the face of its inherent meaninglessness.
- **Implication:** Revolt becomes a life-affirming act, a continuous challenge to the absurd, and a declaration of one's existence.
- **Ought:** Individuals ought to live authentically, fully embracing the human condition and its inherent contradictions. Through revolt, one can find personal freedom and agency.

3. Freedom:

- **Concept:** With the acknowledgment of life's absurdity comes a profound sense of freedom. In a universe devoid of preordained meaning or destiny, individuals are liberated to create their own values and paths.
- **Implication:** This freedom, however, is double-edged—it's both liberating and burdensome, as it places the responsibility of meaning-making squarely on the individual.
- **Ought:** Camus suggests that one ought to exercise this freedom responsibly and authentically, forging a path that resonates with one's personal truths.

4. Ethics of Ambiguity:

- **Concept:** In a world without inherent moral order, ethical decisions become complex. Camus acknowledges the inherent ambiguity in moral choices in an absurd universe.
- **Implication:** Traditional moral systems might fall short in providing clear guidance. Instead, moral decisions are deeply personal and often fraught with uncertainty.

- **Ought:** Individuals ought to approach ethical decisions with a sense of humility and introspection, recognising the inherent ambiguity and doing their best to act with integrity.

5. Nature, Beauty, and Art:

- **Concept:** Despite the weighty themes of absurdity and revolt, Camus also emphasises the role of nature, beauty, and art in human life. These elements can offer solace and moments of transcendence.
- **Implication:** In the face of the absurd, moments of beauty, whether in nature or art, provide brief respites and glimpses of meaning.
- **Ought:** Camus suggests that one ought to seek out and appreciate these moments, allowing them to enrich the human experience and offer a counterpoint to the inherent absurdity of life.

Camus' philosophy, rooted in his personal experiences and the tumultuous events of his time, offers a profound exploration of the human condition. While he paints a picture of a universe indifferent to human desires, he also provides a roadmap for finding personal meaning, agency, and beauty within that vast expanse of indifference. The "oughts" of his philosophy guide individuals on how to live authentically and passionately, even in the shadow of the absurd.

FUNDAMENTAL IDEAS

Existence Precedes Essence:

- **Concept:** Echoing Jean-Paul Sartre, de Beauvoir asserted that individuals are not born with a predetermined nature or essence. Instead, they create their own essence through their actions and choices.
- **Implication:** This means that there's no fixed human nature or predetermined role, especially for women. The roles that women have been assigned in society are not inherent but are constructed.

Ambiguity of Existence:

- **Concept:** De Beauvoir delved deeply into the inherent ambiguity of human existence. Life is full of uncertainties, and the human condition is one of constant tension between our freedom to define ourselves and the limitations imposed by our situations.
- **Implication:** This theme is particularly relevant for women, who face societal constraints that limit their freedom and choices.

Ethics of Liberation:

- **Concept:** De Beauvoir believed in an ethics centered on liberation and authenticity. Individuals should strive to free themselves from societal impositions and live authentically.
- **Implication:** This is especially significant for women, who, according to de Beauvoir, have been historically "imprisoned" by societal norms and roles. They must recognise and challenge these impositions to achieve genuine freedom.

The Other:

- **Concept:** In her seminal work, "The Second Sex," de Beauvoir explores the concept of women being defined as "The Other" in relation to men. Men represent the norm or the subject, while women are the "Other" – the deviant or the object.
- **Implication:** This framework has been used to subordinate women and justify their oppression. Recognising and challenging this dynamic is crucial for women's liberation.

Situationality:

- **Concept:** While individuals have the freedom to define themselves, de Beauvoir emphasised that this freedom is always exercised within a particular situation or context. These situations, especially for women, often come with constraints.
- **Implication:** The societal situation, with its patriarchal structures, often limits women's freedoms. Recognising these limitations is the first step toward challenging and overcoming them.

Relationships and Dependency:

- **Concept:** De Beauvoir explored the dynamics of relationships, particularly highlighting how societal norms can lead to imbalanced, dependent relationships, especially in the context of heterosexual romantic relationships.
- **Implication:** Such dependencies can hinder women's freedom and self-realisation. Genuine relationships should be based on mutual respect and recognition.

Freedom and Responsibility:

- **Concept:** True freedom, for de Beauvoir, is not just the absence of external constraints but also involves taking responsibility for one's actions and choices.
- **Implication:** Women must not only seek liberation from external impositions but also take active responsibility for defining themselves and their roles in society.

In essence, Simone de Beauvoir's existentialism is deeply intertwined with her feminist philosophy. She uses existentialist concepts to analyse, critique, and challenge the societal structures and norms that have historically oppressed women. Her work calls for a radical redefinition of gender roles and relationships, advocating for a world where individuals, regardless of gender, can define their own essences and live authentically.

Simone de Beauvoir's Biography and Context:

Early Life:

Born in Paris in 1908, de Beauvoir hailed from a bourgeois family. Her early years were marked by a staunch religious upbringing, which she later rejected, pivoting towards atheism and existentialism.

This transition from religiosity to existentialism influenced her views on freedom, responsibility, and the absence of preordained human essence.

Academic Pursuits:

De Beauvoir studied at the Sorbonne (University of Paris), where she studied philosophy. It was here that she met Jean-Paul Sartre, establishing a lifelong relationship and intellectual partnership.

Her academic training and close association with Sartre laid the foundation for her existentialist leanings, though she would develop unique perspectives, especially concerning women's experiences.

Personal and Intellectual Relationships:

De Beauvoir and Sartre shared an unconventional relationship, both romantic and intellectual, that lasted for decades. They maintained an open relationship, emphasising individual freedom and authenticity.

Their relationship, built on mutual respect and intellectual exchange, influenced both of their works. De Beauvoir and Sartre often discussed, critiqued, and contributed to each other's writings.

Feminism and "The Second Sex":

In 1949, de Beauvoir published "The Second Sex," a groundbreaking work that combined existentialism with a critique of women's oppression. In it, she famously declared, "One is not born, but rather becomes, a woman."

This work positioned de Beauvoir as a foundational figure in feminist philosophy. She applied existentialist ideas to the condition of women, arguing that cultural and societal norms, rather than biology, defined and limited women's roles.

Engagement with Other Thinkers:

Beyond Sartre, de Beauvoir engaged with various intellectuals of her time, including Albert Camus, Merleau-Ponty, and the phenomenologist Edmund Husserl.

These engagements enriched her existentialist thought, integrating phenomenological insights with her unique perspectives on gender and existential freedom.

Later Life and Activism:

De Beauvoir became politically active, advocating for women's rights, participating in the feminist movement, and addressing other social issues. She traveled extensively, which further influenced her perspectives.

Her activism and writings in her later years reflected a deep commitment to existentialist principles, particularly concerning freedom, authenticity, and societal responsibility.

Legacy:

De Beauvoir's influence extended beyond existentialism to encompass feminist theory, literature, and social critique. Her works have been foundational texts in gender studies and existential philosophy.

De Beauvoir's integration of existentialist thought with a profound exploration of gender and society has solidified her legacy as one of the most influential thinkers of the 20th century.

KEY IDEAS

1) Existence Precedes Essence:

De Beauvoir rejected the notion of a fixed essence or predetermined nature for individuals. This perspective underlines the idea that identity, including gender, is not a fixed entity but something constructed and chosen.

Extended: She challenges the traditional gender roles and norms imposed by society. By asserting that existence precedes essence, de Beauvoir is emphasising the potential fluidity of gender and identity.

What we Ought to do: Individuals ought to recognise the societal constructs that influence their understanding of gender and identity and should be empowered to define and embrace their authentic selves.

2) Ambiguity of Existence:

Life's inherent ambiguity arises from the tension between individual freedom and societal constraints. This tension is especially pronounced for women and marginalised groups.

Extended: De Beauvoir's analysis of this ambiguity provides a framework for understanding the relationship between individual agency and societal pressures in shaping identity.

What we Ought to do: Individuals ought to embrace and navigate this ambiguity, striving to exercise their agency even within the constraints of their specific situations.

3) Ethics of Liberation:

De Beauvoir's ethics are centred on the idea of liberation from oppressive societal norms and the pursuit of an authentic existence.

Extended: This liberation is not just about breaking free from external constraints but also involves an internal journey of self-discovery and affirmation.

What we Ought to do: People ought to challenge and resist oppressive norms and structures, seeking a life of authenticity and self-definition.

4) The Other:

The dynamic of defining women as "The Other" relative to men underlines the systemic marginalisation of women.

Extended: This concept of "othering" extends to contemporary discussions on prejudice, where marginalised groups are often positioned as the "deviant" or "abnormal" in relation to the dominant culture.

What we Ought to do: Society ought to challenge and deconstruct these binaries, recognising the inherent value and equality of all individuals, irrespective of their identity.

5) Situationality:

While individuals possess freedom, this freedom is always exercised within the confines of a particular situation.

Extended: De Beauvoir's emphasis on situationality underscores the need to understand the specific personal histories that shape individual experiences and identities.

What we Ought to do: Individuals ought to be critically aware of their personal histories, using this awareness as a tool for informed decision-making and self-definition.

6) Relationships and Dependency:

De Beauvoir delved into the complexities of human relationships, critiquing the imbalances and dependencies that societal norms can foster.

Extended: Her insights into the dynamics of relationships shed light on the ways in which societal constructs, like heteronormativity, can shape interpersonal dynamics and self-perceptions.

What we Ought to do: Individuals ought to seek relationships based on mutual respect, understanding, and equality, challenging traditional power dynamics and dependencies.

7) Freedom and Responsibility:

For de Beauvoir, genuine freedom is intertwined with responsibility. It's not just about the absence of constraints but also about taking responsibility for one's choices and actions.

Extended: This perspective emphasises the active role individuals play in shaping their destinies, even in the face of external pressures.

What we Ought to do: Individuals ought to exercise their freedom with a sense of responsibility, always striving for authenticity and integrity in their choices.

SUMMARY

Simone de Beauvoir's philosophy explores identity, freedom, and social influences. While rooted in existentialism, her work offers a pioneering perspective on gender and identity, emphasising the importance of defining ourselves by resisting oppressive norms and pursuing an authentic existence. Her insight remains relevant in contemporary discussions on gender, sexuality, and identity politics.

FUNDAMENTAL IDEAS

Existence Precedes Essence:

- **Concept:** Like de Beauvoir, one of the most fundamental tenets of Sartre's existentialism is the idea that "existence precedes essence." In simple terms, it means that individuals first exist, encounter themselves, and then define their essence or nature through their actions and choices.
- **Implication:** This rejects the notion of a predetermined human nature or essence. There's no fixed "human nature" since there's no God or external entity to define such a nature. Thus, individuals are responsible for creating their own essence through their choices and actions.

Radical Freedom:

- **Concept:** Sartre believed that humans are condemned to be free. There's no external force or destiny determining our actions. Every choice we make defines our essence.
- **Implication:** This freedom is both liberating and burdensome. While it allows individuals to shape their destinies, it also brings the weight of responsibility for every action and its consequences.

Bad Faith (Mauvaise foi):

- **Concept:** Sartre introduced the notion of "bad faith" as a form of self-deception. It's the act of denying one's complete freedom and responsibility by attributing one's actions to external causes or societal norms.
- **Implication:** Living in bad faith is living inauthentically. It's a way to escape the anxiety of freedom by conforming to societal expectations or attributing decisions to factors beyond one's control.

Anguish and Absurdity:

- **Concept:** Recognising one's complete freedom and the absence of any predetermined essence or moral framework leads to feelings of anguish and absurdity.
- **Implication:** The world lacks inherent meaning, and the realisation of this can lead to a sense of despair. However, it also opens the door for individuals to create their own meanings and values.

The Look and the Other:

- **Concept:** In his work "Being and Nothingness," Sartre explores the idea of "the Look." It's the awareness that others can perceive us, leading to a feeling of being objectified or defined by their perceptions.

- **Implication:** This introduces the idea that our self-awareness and identity are shaped not only by our internal perceptions but also by our interactions and relationships with others.

Commitment and Action:

- **Concept:** For Sartre, existentialism isn't just a philosophical contemplation but a call to action. Individuals should be committed to their choices and take active roles in shaping their destinies and the world around them.
- **Implication:** Authentic existence involves not just recognising one's freedom but actively engaging with the world, making choices, and taking responsibility for their outcomes.

Existential Marxism:

- **Concept:** Later in his life, Sartre attempted to reconcile existentialism with Marxism, emphasising the role of societal structures in shaping individual experiences while maintaining the core existentialist tenets of freedom and responsibility.
- **Implication:** This synthesis aimed to combine the individual freedom emphasised by existentialism with the societal critique offered by Marxism.

In essence, Jean-Paul Sartre's existentialism delves deeply into the human condition, exploring themes of freedom, responsibility, authenticity, and interpersonal relationships. It offers a profound reflection on the nature of existence, the challenges of freedom, and the quest for authentic living in a world devoid of inherent meaning.

Jean-Paul Sartre's Biography and Context:

Sartre's existentialism was deeply rooted in his life's events and the thinkers he engaged with.

Early Life:

Born in Paris in 1905, Sartre lost his father at a young age and was raised by his mother and maternal grandfather. His early years were marked by a passion for literature and philosophy.

Academic Pursuits:

Sartre studied at the École Normale Supérieure in Paris, where he formed significant friendships, most notably with Simone de Beauvoir. He was influenced by German phenomenology, especially the works of Edmund Husserl and Martin Heidegger.

World War II and Resistance:

Sartre served as a soldier during World War II and was captured by German forces in 1940. He spent around a year as a prisoner of war before being released. After his return to Paris, he became an active member of the French Resistance.

His wartime experiences, witnessing human resilience, freedom, and despair amidst oppression, deeply influenced his existentialist writings. The themes of freedom, responsibility, and action became even more pronounced in his work.

Post-War Paris:

After the war, Sartre became a central figure in the Parisian intellectual scene. He founded the influential journal "Les Temps Modernes" and engaged in various political and social issues.

His post-war writings and activism reflect a commitment to existentialist principles applied to real-world issues, emphasising individual freedom and societal responsibility.

Engagement with Other Thinkers:

Sartre's existentialism was in dialogue with other existential thinkers like Albert Camus, Friedrich Nietzsche, and Fyodor Dostoevsky. However, he had disagreements, most notably with Camus over issues like revolutionary violence.

These engagements enriched his thought, leading to both convergences and divergences with other existentialist thinkers.

Jean-Paul Sartre's Existential Philosophy:

1. Existence Precedes Essence:

Sartre's foundational claim is that existence comes before essence for humans. Unlike inanimate objects, humans are not born with a predetermined purpose or nature. Instead, they forge their essence through their choices and actions in the world.

Extended: In a world devoid of divine determination, humans are thrown into existence with the freedom to define themselves. This freedom is both a blessing and a curse: it allows for self-definition but also carries the weight of responsibility.

What we Ought to do: Sartre believed individuals ought to recognise and embrace their radical freedom. They should not hide behind societal norms or preconceived roles but instead actively define their essence through authentic choices.

2. Radical Freedom and Responsibility:

Sartre posited that humans possess an immense degree of freedom. Even in situations of external constraint, individuals retain the freedom of choice in how they respond or interpret their circumstances.

Extended: This freedom, however, is accompanied by a profound sense of responsibility. Every choice made contributes to defining one's essence and, in a broader sense, contributes to defining what it means to be human.

What we Ought to do: Individuals ought to be acutely aware of their freedom and the corresponding responsibility. They should act authentically, understanding that each action has consequences not just for oneself but for the collective definition of humanity.

3. Bad Faith (Mauvaise foi):

Bad faith is the act of self-deception, where individuals deny their freedom and responsibility, often to avoid the anxiety associated with them.

Extended: People in bad faith might attribute their actions to societal norms, their role in society, or external circumstances. By doing so, they escape the existential anguish of freedom but live inauthentically.

What we Ought to do: Sartre argued that individuals ought to confront and overcome bad faith. They should recognise and accept their freedom and the inherent responsibility, striving for authenticity even when it's uncomfortable.

4. Anguish and Absurdity:

Recognising one's freedom and the lack of inherent meaning or moral structure in the world can lead to feelings of anguish and a sense of absurdity.

Extended: The absurdity stems from the realisation that the world lacks inherent purpose, yet humans continuously seek meaning. Anguish is the emotional response to the weight of freedom and the responsibility it entails.

What we Ought to do: While these feelings are natural, Sartre believed individuals ought to confront them head-on. Instead of succumbing to despair, they should create their own meaning and values, forging purpose in an indifferent universe.

5. The Look and the Other:

Sartre explored interpersonal dynamics, emphasising how individuals become objectified in the gaze of the other. This realisation that one is being perceived can lead to feelings of objectification and alienation.

Extended: This dynamic highlights the tension between one's subjective experience and the external perception of oneself. It underscores the complexities of human relationships and the challenge of maintaining authenticity in interpersonal interactions.

What we Ought to do: Sartre suggested that individuals ought to be aware of this dynamic, striving for genuine relationships based on mutual recognition and respect, rather than reducing the other to mere objects.

6. Commitment and Action:

Beyond abstract contemplation, Sartre's existentialism is a call to committed action in the world.

Extended: In a universe devoid of preordained values, individuals have the responsibility to create values through their actions. These actions not only define the individual but also shape the world.

What we Ought to do: Sartre believed individuals ought to be actively engaged in the world. Authentic existence involves not only recognising one's freedom and responsibility but also acting on them, committedly shaping one's destiny and contributing to societal change.

At its core, Sartre's existentialism is a call to action—a call for individuals to recognise their radical freedom, confront the inherent challenges of existence, and actively shape their destinies in an ever-complex world.

Fundamental Themes of Frankl's Existentialism:

1. **The Search for Meaning:** Central to Frankl's philosophy is the idea that life's primary motivational force is the search for meaning. This contrasts with Freud's theory that pleasure is the primary motivator and Adler's idea of power as the main drive.
2. **Freedom of Will:** Frankl believed that humans have the freedom to find meaning in whatever situation they are in, even in suffering and death.
3. **Will to Meaning:** Unlike the will to power or the will to pleasure, Frankl posited a "will to meaning" as a central aspect of human nature.
4. **Existential Frustration:** When individuals cannot realise their "will to meaning", they experience existential frustration, which can lead to neuroses.
5. **Tragic Optimism:** The idea that even in the face of suffering, guilt, and death, one can still find meaning and thus a reason to be optimistic.

Basic History Informing His Existentialism:

Biography: Viktor Frankl was an Austrian neurologist and psychiatrist. He was a Holocaust survivor, having spent three years in concentration camps, including Auschwitz. His experiences in the camps deeply influenced his philosophical outlook and led to the development of his unique form of existential therapy called logotherapy.

Relation to Other Existentialists: While Frankl's ideas resonate with those of other existentialists, especially in terms of the emphasis on personal freedom, responsibility, and the search for meaning, his approach is less abstract and more clinical. His experiences in concentration camps gave his philosophy a tangible, real-world application.

Contemporaries: Frankl's work bridged the gap between existential philosophy and psychotherapy. While contemporaries like Sartre and Camus were discussing existential ideas in philosophical terms, Frankl was applying these concepts in a therapeutic setting. His ideas also contrasted with the predominant psychoanalytic theories of his time, which focused on the unconscious mind and past traumas.

Closer Outline of Frankl's Philosophy:

Logotherapy: Derived from the Greek word "logos", which means "meaning", logotherapy is a form of existential psychotherapy that emphasises the human capacity to transcend suffering and find meaning in life.

Three Ways to Find Meaning: According to Frankl, there are three primary ways through which one can find meaning:

1. **By Creating a Work or Doing a Deed.**

2. **By Experiencing Something or Encountering Someone** (love, for instance).

3. **By the Attitude We Take Toward Unavoidable Suffering.**

Confronting the Unconscious: Unlike Freudian psychoanalysis, which seeks to delve into the unconscious to unearth traumas, logotherapy focuses on the future and the conscious actions and decisions that can bring meaning.

Defiant Power of the Human Spirit: Frankl believed in the human ability to rise above circumstances, including immense suffering. He believed that individuals have the power to choose their reactions to situations, thus demonstrating the defiant power of the human spirit.

The 'Oughts' of His Work: Frankl's work essentially tells us that:

- We **ought** to search for meaning in our lives.
- We **ought** to recognise that even in the face of immense suffering, we have a choice in how we respond.
- We **ought** to understand that life has potential meaning under any circumstances, even the most miserable ones.
- We **ought** to know that our main concern is not to gain pleasure or to avoid pain but rather to see a meaning in our life.
- We **ought** to realise that there's always hope, as long as we find meaning, even in the bleakest situations.

Frankl's philosophy is not just theoretical but is grounded in his own lived experiences, making it profoundly impactful and resonant. He offers a perspective that is both deeply human and inherently hopeful.